



STATE police officers examine an abandoned truck riddled with bullet holes in La Ciénega, Mexico, in June.

COLUMN ONE

Gold, guns and cartels: The battle for a billion-dollar Mexican mine

A Newport Beach businessman sought to repay the orphanage that once saved him. The dangerous drug network of El Chapo's sons stood in his way.

By Steve Fisher
REPORTING FROM
LA CIÉNEGA, MEXICO

Barreling down the highway at 100 mph, a convoy of state police vehicles blew through speed bumps as it entered a small town in the Sonoran Desert. Blasting over them was hell, but Alejandro Sánchez knew that slowing down was too risky. Here, locals call them “death bumps,” because reducing your speed gives cartel snipers a better chance of taking you out.

Sánchez and the officers protecting him had left Hermosillo, the capital of the state of Sonora, before sunrise on June 23 and by 7 a.m. had arrived in Altar. There's not much pedestrian traffic because the town sits in the heart of a cartel war zone, and anyone who walks the streets risks being caught in cross-fire.

Still, it was a place to gather reinforcements, so the convoy stopped under the town's welcome arch and officers wielding AR-15 semiautomatic weapons found high ground to watch for threats. Within minutes, four more patrol trucks raced up to join the security detail.

Their destination: a gold mine. Sánchez, the officers knew, was key to the mine's future and keeping it out of the hands of a major cartel.

For three years, Sánchez had worked to revive the mine, encountering corrupt officials and cartel operatives. He once had to dive for cover during a firefight. But now he was close to resuming operations at the mine with deposits worth billions.

“Let's go!” Sánchez said. And they were off.

FÉLIX MÁRQUEZ For The Times

Volunteers race to preserve history

BY JACK DOLAN

A famous Civil War-era photo of an escaped enslaved man who had been savagely whipped. Displays detailing how more than 120,000 U.S. citizens of Japanese ancestry were forcibly imprisoned during World War II. Signs describing the effects of climate change on the coast of Maine.

In recent months, a small army of historians, librarians, scientists and other volunteers has fanned out across America's national parks and museums to photograph and painstakingly archive cultural and intellectual treasures they fear are under threat from President Trump's war against “woke.”

These volunteers are creating a “citizen's record” of what exists now in case the administration carries out

A small army works to save cultural treasures amid war against ‘woke’



KEN WELSH Design Pics/Universal Images Group

TRUMP OFFICIALS denied reports that a photo of an enslaved man's scars had been ordered removed.

Trump's orders to scrub public signs and displays of language he and his allies deem too negative about America's past.

“My deepest, darkest fear,” said Georgetown University history professor Chandra Manning, who helped organize an effort dubbed Citizen Historians for the Smithsonian, is that the administration plans to “rewrite and falsify who counts as an American.”

In March, Trump issued an executive order entitled “Restoring Truth and Sanity to American History,” arguing that, over the last decade, signs and displays at museums and parks across the country have been distorted by a “widespread effort to rewrite our Nation's history,” replacing facts with liberal ideology.

“Under this historical revision,” he wrote, “our Na-

Reputed mobster charged with Beverly Hills poker shakedown

BY MATTHEW ORMSETH

Threats. A torched Bentley. Gunshots in the Hollywood Hills.

A network of private, high-dollar poker games in Los Angeles and Beverly Hills has been roiled by shakedowns and violence perpetrated by alleged Israeli organized crime figures, according to a federal agent's affidavit filed recently in federal court.

The document describes how a reputed crime figure, Assaf “Ace” Wagnine, allegedly tried taking a cut of the profits from a weekly card game in which players at times won and lost millions in a night.

When the host of the game balked, the affidavit said, Wagnine alluded to the 2023 death of Emil Lahaziel, who was shot in the face as he walked out of a poker game in the Hollywood Hills.

“I guess you really want to end up like your other b— a— poker buddy,” Wagnine wrote in a text message, according to the affidavit.

The document was filed in support of charges against Wagnine, 52, for transmitting threatening communications in interstate and foreign commerce. An Israeli national who was deported from the United States in 2011, Wagnine is not in custody and is believed to be living in Mexico, the affidavit said.

His lawyer, Brett Greenfield, said Wagnine denied having threatened people or extorted money from them. “That's just not what he does,” he said.

Greenfield said he was trying to learn more about the charges from the U.S. attorney's office in Los Angeles and declined to comment further.

In the affidavit, Homeland Security Investigations special agent Matthew Hernandez claimed Wagnine and his brother Hai leveraged their “longstanding reputations for violence to promote a climate of fear” within Los Angeles' Israeli community.

Hai Wagnine, who was

[See Poker, A6]

California steps in as U.S. skips climate summit

Golden State aims to build on its reputation as a global leader at talks in Belém, Brazil.

By Hayley Smith
and Melody Gutierrez

Nearly 200 nations are gathering in Belém, Brazil, to kick off the annual United Nations climate policy summit, but there is one glaring exception: The Trump administration is not sending any high-ranking officials.

California hopes it can fill the gap. The state, as it usually does, is sending a large delegation to the Conference of the Parties, including first-time attendee Gov. Gavin Newsom and top officials from the California Natural Resources Agency, Department of Food and Agriculture, Air Resources Board, Public Utilities Commission and Governor's Office of Tribal Affairs.

The state aims to build on its reputation as a global climate leader, sharing its experience with clean energy technology and job creation and showcasing its track record of climate agreements with other countries and regions.

Newsom, who is positioning himself for a 2028 presidential run, told The Times he “absolutely” sees California as a proxy for the U.S. at this year's conference, which is the main global venue for countries to strengthen their commitments to reducing greenhouse gases.

“California has a responsibility, but also a unique opportunity,” he said.

[See Climate, A10]

Lead, asbestos found in homes after fire cleanup

By Noah Haggerty

In a sample of still-standing homes within the area the Eaton fire's ash settled, more than half had significant lead contamination even after extensive indoor remediation efforts, according to new findings from the grassroots advocacy group Eaton Fire Residents United. Additionally, a third of remediated homes tested positive for asbestos.

The results released last week from 50 homes within and downwind of the Eaton burn area provide the first

widespread evidence that the remediation techniques pushed by insurance companies and public health officials have not sufficiently removed contaminants deposited by the fire.

Long-term exposure to asbestos increases the risk of developing mesothelioma and other cancers, and long-term exposure to lead can cause permanent brain damage, especially in children, that leads to developmental delays and behavioral problems. No level of exposure to lead and asbestos comes without risks of

Edison blackouts increase sharply

The utility warns of longer power shutoffs. Residents fear safety and health risks.

By Melody Petersen

Southern California Edison has cut power to hundreds of thousands of its customers this year, more than ever before, as it attempts to stop its electric lines from sparking wildfires.

The utility has told communities in fire-prone areas in recent weeks that they

should expect more of the power shutoffs than in prior years and that the outages could last for longer periods of time.

The Rosemead-based company said it had lowered the wind speed that triggers the blackouts, and added tens of thousands of customers to the areas subject to them, after the devastating Jan. 7 Eaton fire. The inferno, which killed 19 people in Altadena, ignited in high winds under an Edison transmission line.

“You should be ready for the power to cut off at any moment,” Ian Anderson, a

[See Blackouts, A10]



JED JACOBSON Associated Press

RAMS' REVENGE

Davante Adams and the offense were in command in a 42-26 win at San Francisco, avenging last month's loss to the rival 49ers. **SPORTS, D1**

Two leaders at BBC resign

The public broadcaster has faced criticism over the way a Trump speech was edited. **WORLD, A4**

Order to ‘undo’ SNAP payments

Trump administration warns of penalties if states defy its directive on anti-hunger program. **NATION, A5**

Street art revolt against ICE raids

Images projected onto buildings in L.A. and Long Beach ask: “Am I Next?” **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 87/62. **B5**



7 85944 00200 5